

CSS Text

Complete Guide with Code Examples & Practical Usage

Introduction

CSS text properties control the appearance and layout of text content on web pages. From colors and sizes to alignment and decorations, text styling is essential for readability, visual hierarchy, and overall design. This comprehensive guide covers all text properties, techniques, and best practices for professional text styling.

Text Properties Reference

Property	Description	Example Values
color	Text color	#e91e63, rgb(233, 30, 99), red
font-size	Text size	12px, 1.5em, 2rem, small, large
font-weight	Text thickness	300, 400, 700, 900, bold, normal
font-style	Text angle	normal, italic, oblique
text-transform	Text capitalization	uppercase, lowercase, capitalize
text-decoration	Text underline/overline	underline, line-through, none
text-shadow	Text shadow effect	2px 2px 4px rgba(0,0,0,0.3)
text-align	Text alignment	left, center, right, justify
line-height	Space between lines	1.5, 2, 1.6em, 24px
letter-spacing	Space between characters	2px, 0.1em, normal

Example 1: Text Color

Control text color with multiple formats.

CSS Code:

```
/* Different color formats */ p { color: #e91e63; } /* Hex */ p { color: rgb(233, 30, 99); } /* RGB */ p { color: rgba(233, 30, 99, 0.8); } /* RGBA with transparency */ p { color: pink; } /* Named color */
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="color: #e91e63;">Colored text</p>
```

Live Demo:

This text is colored with #e91e63

Example 2: Font Size

Different ways to specify text size.

CSS Code:

```
/* Absolute sizes */ p { font-size: 12px; } /* Pixels */ p { font-size: 1.5em; } /* Em (relative to parent) */ p { font-size: 2rem; } /* Rem (relative to root) */ /* Keywords */ p { font-size: small; } p { font-size: medium; } p { font-size: large; }
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="font-size: 16px;">Normal text</p> <p style="font-size: 24px;">Large text</p>
```

Live Demo:

Small text (12px)

Normal text (16px)

Large text (24px)

Example 3: Font Weight

Control text thickness from light to heavy.

CSS Code:

```
/* Numeric values */ p { font-weight: 300; } /* Light */ p { font-weight: 400; } /* Normal */ p { font-weight: 700; } /* Bold */ p { font-weight: 900; } /* Heavy */ /* Keywords */ p { font-weight: normal; } p { font-weight: bold; }
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="font-weight: 700;">Bold text</p>
```

Live Demo:

Light text (300)

Normal text (400)

Bold text (700)

Heavy text (900)

Example 4: Font Style

Italic and oblique text styling.

CSS Code:

```
/* Font styles */ p { font-style: normal; } /* Default */ p { font-style: italic; } /* Slanted */ p { font-style: oblique; } /* Mathematically slanted */
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="font-style: italic;">Italic text</p>
```

Live Demo:

Italic text

Oblique text

Example 5: Text Transform

Control text capitalization automatically.

CSS Code:

```
/* Text transformation */ p { text-transform: uppercase; } /* ALL CAPS */ p { text-transform: lowercase; } /* all lowercase */ p { text-transform: capitalize; } /* Each Word Capitalized */ p { text-transform: none; } /* Default */
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="text-transform: uppercase;"> This will be all caps </p>
```

Live Demo:

THIS TEXT BECOMES UPPERCASE

this text becomes lowercase

This Text Is Capitalized

Example 6: Text Decoration

Add underline, overline, or strikethrough effects.

CSS Code:

```
/* Text decoration */ p { text-decoration: underline; } /* Underline */ p { text-decoration: line-through; } /* Strikethrough */ p { text-decoration: overline; } /* Overline */ p { text-decoration: none; } /* Remove */ /* Decoration color (separate property) */ p { text-decoration: underline, text-decoration-color: #e91e63; }
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="text-decoration: underline;">Underlined</p>
```

Live Demo:

Underlined text

~~Strikethrough text~~

No decoration

Example 7: Text Shadow

Add depth with text shadow effects.

CSS Code:

```
/* Text shadow: offset-x offset-y blur-radius color */ p { text-shadow: 2px 2px 4px rgba(0,0,0,0.3); } /* Multiple shadows */ p { text-shadow: 2px 2px 4px rgba(0,0,0,0.3), 4px 4px 8px rgba(0,0,0,0.2); }
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="text-shadow: 2px 2px 4px rgba(0,0,0,0.3);"> Shadow text </p>
```

Live Demo:

Text with shadow effect

Example 8: Text Alignment

Align text left, center, right, or justified.

CSS Code:

```
/* Text alignment */ p { text-align: left; } /* Left aligned */ p { text-align: center; } /* Centered */ p { text-align: right; } /* Right aligned */ p { text-align: justify; } /* Justified */
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="text-align: center;">Centered text</p>
```

Live Demo:

Left aligned text stays on the left side

Centered text in the middle

Right aligned text on right

Example 9: Line Height

Control vertical spacing between text lines.

CSS Code:

```
/* Line height */ p { line-height: 1; } /* Single spacing */ p { line-height: 1.5; } /* 1.5x spacing */ p { line-height: 2; } /* Double spacing */ p { line-height: 24px; } /* Fixed pixels */ p { line-height: 1.6em; } /* Em units */
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="line-height: 1.6;"> Text with comfortable line spacing for readability </p>
```

Live Demo:

This text has a larger line-height (2) which creates more vertical space between lines, making it easier to read longer passages of text

Example 10: Letter Spacing

Adjust horizontal space between characters.

CSS Code:

```
/* Letter spacing */ p { letter-spacing: normal; } /* Default */ p { letter-spacing: 2px; } /* Pixels */ p { letter-spacing: 0.1em; } /* Em units */ p { letter-spacing: -1px; } /* Negative (condensed) */
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="letter-spacing: 2px;"> Spaced out text </p>
```

Live Demo:

This text has increased letter spacing

Example 11: Text Overflow

Handle text that exceeds container width.

CSS Code:

```
/* Text overflow */ p { white-space: nowrap; overflow: hidden; text-overflow: ellipsis; } /* ... at end */ /* Word wrapping */ p { word-wrap: break-word; overflow-wrap: break-word; }
```

HTML Usage:

```
<p style="white-space: nowrap; overflow: hidden; text-overflow: ellipsis; width: 200px;"> This text will be truncated with ellipsis </p>
```

Live Demo:

This is a very long te...

Best Practices

1. Maintain Readability

```
body { font-size: 16px; /* Comfortable base size */ line-height: 1.6; /* Proper spacing between lines */ color: #333; /* High contrast for readability */ } p { max-width: 75ch; /* ~75 characters per line */ margin-bottom: 1.5em; /* Spacing between paragraphs */ }
```

2. Use Font Scale for Hierarchy

```
h2 { font-size: 2.5rem; font-weight: 700; } h2 { font-size: 2rem; font-weight: 700; } h3 { font-size: 1.5rem; font-weight: 600; } p { font-size: 1rem; font-weight: 400; }
```

3. Sufficient Color Contrast

```
/* ✓ Good contrast */ p { color: #333; background: white; } /* ✗ Poor contrast */ p { color: #ccc; background: white; }
```

4. Responsive Text Sizing

```
body { font-size: 16px; /* Desktop */ } @media (max-width: 768px) { body { font-size: 14px; } /* Tablet */ } @media (max-width: 480px) { body { font-size: 12px; } /* Mobile */ }
```

5. Proper Line Height for Readability

```
/* General readability */ body { line-height: 1.6; } /* Large text blocks */ article { line-height: 1.8; } /* Headings (tighter) */ h1, h2, h3 { line-height: 1.2; }
```

💡 **Tip:** A good line-height is 1.5 to 1.8 for body text. This provides comfortable reading and reduces eye strain, especially for longer paragraphs.

Common Issues & Solutions

Issue: Text Too Small to Read

Problem:

```
p { font-size: 10px; } /* Too small */
```

Solution:

```
p { font-size: 16px; /* Comfortable size */ line-height: 1.6; /* Better spacing */ }
```

Issue: Poor Contrast on Colored Background

Problem:

```
p { color: #999; background: #f0f0f0; } /* Low contrast */
```

Solution:

```
p { color: #333; background: #f0f0f0; } /* High contrast */
```

Issue: Text Overflowing Container

Problem:

```
p { width: 200px; } /* Long words break layout */
```

Solution:

```
p { width: 200px; word-wrap: break-word; overflow-wrap: break-word; }
```

Summary

- Use **font-size: 16px** as comfortable base size
- Set **line-height: 1.6** for readable line spacing
- Ensure **color contrast** for accessibility
- Use **font-weight** to create visual hierarchy
- Apply **text-align** for proper alignment
- Use **text-decoration** sparingly for emphasis
- Control spacing with **letter-spacing** and **line-height**
- Add **text-shadow** for depth effects
- Use **text-overflow: ellipsis** for long text
- Test text styling on different devices
- Maintain consistent typography throughout site